

Inspection of Haringey local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 12 to 16 January 2026

Lead inspector: Christine Kennet, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding
Overall effectiveness	Outstanding

Strong and stable strategic direction is underpinned by a clear and shared commitment from leaders to improving outcomes for children and families. Sustained transformation, focused on early intervention, prevention and strong social work practice, has supported children to remain within their family networks and reduced the number who enter care. Leaders are responding ambitiously and creatively to budget pressures and constraints in partner capacity, aligning local priorities with national social care reforms and strengthening partnership working. Leaders have established evidence-informed learning cultures that support consistently good or outstanding practice across all services.

Early help services support and contribute to reducing harm for all age groups through 4 family hubs. If children need help or protection, statutory services respond quickly to risks at the appropriate level. Most children in care live in well-matched, stable homes that are meeting their needs. Care leavers have established relationships with their workers, who are ambitious for them and proactive. There is a clear focus on timely, child-centred and family-led practice.

Quality assurance is purposeful and transparent, providing leaders with clear oversight of practice quality and outcomes. Workforce diversity is evident at all levels

and reflects the community that Haringey serves. While for a small number of children, practice could be improved through earlier safety planning and management oversight, overall practice has significantly improved since the last ILACS inspection in 2023.

What needs to improve?¹

- The timeliness of initial safety planning for a small number of disabled children when a risk of harm is suspected. (outcome 3, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. An increasingly comprehensive and effective suite of early help provision across Haringey is helping to provide easy access and timely support to children and their families. Universal and targeted early help delivered through family hubs is well coordinated and contributes to reducing risk of harm across all age groups. Referrals are allocated promptly, with clear guidance from managers on expectations and focus.
2. Early help assessments are thorough and comprehensively consider children's unique needs and circumstances. Workers involve children and families in identifying what needs to change and how changes will be achieved. Plans are proportionate to need and co-produced with families and multi-agency partners. They are regularly reviewed and demonstrate positive impact. The interface between early help and social work services is clearly differentiated, so that children receive the right level of support when their circumstances or needs change. Earlier identification of needs and family-led planning is addressing disproportionality across the borough.
3. Haringey's multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH) is highly effective, providing timely and proportionate responses to contacts that raise concerns about children's wellbeing. The co-location of early help managers and a wide range of relevant professionals is a notable strength, enabling swift information-sharing and supporting intelligent, well-reasoned decisions.
4. Staff in the MASH are knowledgeable and experienced. They take time to engage parents and, when appropriate, children to ensure that decision-making is informed by their views and lived experiences. Managers maintain strong oversight and have a good understanding of the breadth of risks affecting individual children, including domestic abuse, substance misuse, exploitation and serious youth violence. Prompt and well-informed screening decisions consistently

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

shape appropriate next steps, ensuring that children are directed to the right level of support at the earliest opportunity.

5. Leaders have further strengthened the out-of-hours service since the last inspection in 2023. Children are routinely visited and strategy meetings are held when needed. Risk assessments are completed promptly, which supports a protective response. Communication to daytime services via a daily meeting in the MASH ensures that prompt, continued support is offered.
6. When there are concerns that children may be at risk of significant harm, strategy discussions and child protection enquiries are convened quickly, with good multi-agency attendance, relevant information-sharing and appropriate decision-making to assess risks and meet children's needs.
7. Assessments are holistic and child focused. Social workers use play-based and direct work approaches to understand children's daily experiences, including sensitive observations of babies. Assessments create meaningful opportunities for parents and carers to reflect and consider change, and interventions begin without delay.
8. Young carers are not consistently identified. Some receive the strong support available from the young carers service through early help assessment, but others may be missed because statutory assessments do not always explore children's caring responsibilities when parents have additional needs.
9. Child in need and child protection plans are clearly set out and are regularly reviewed. Social workers complete focused work at the child's pace, and children's cases stay open longer when needed to sustain change. Practice is sensitive and challenges specific cultural boundaries respectfully. Progress is monitored and reviewed closely. When improvements are not sustained, children's needs are escalated appropriately to the pre-proceedings stages of the Public Law Outline (PLO), with PLO tracking and panels helping to prevent delay and ensure that the right care is achieved swiftly for these particularly vulnerable children.
10. The disabled children's team completes thorough, child-centred assessments. Direct work is creative, interpreters are used well, and children's wishes and feelings inform planning. Chronologies are up to date, but management oversight is not always clearly recorded, and for a small number of children, safety planning and partner communication is not always sufficiently timely when significant harm is suspected.
11. Leaders have strengthened oversight and systems for identifying and supporting privately fostered children since the last inspection. Assessments are completed on time, supported by a dedicated lead practitioner. Online resources, newsletters and multi-agency collaboration have increased awareness across agencies, leading to a rise in identified children and children being appropriately monitored and supported.

12. Interventions and direct work are carefully tailored to children's individual needs and are underpinned by highly skilled, child-centred practice. Social workers benefit from training and guidance and feel supported and valued, enabling them to maintain a strong focus on children's experiences.
13. Parenting capacity assessments and family group conferences are used well to support children remaining safely in their own family networks when possible and in their best interest. Management oversight is strong, and escalation pathways are used effectively when parents cannot meet their children's needs.
14. Family-led interventions at the 'Rising Roots' hub (a family hub for assessments) empower families and create a hopeful, supportive environment for children in pre-proceedings or care proceedings, drawing on their strengths and networks. Quality family time is supported when children are no longer living in their own families, until decisions are made about their care plans.
15. There is a proactive approach to identifying and responding to exploitation. Early identification through the MASH, specialist community services and strong multi-agency collaboration help reduce harm. Whole-family work and regular visits support children to disengage from risky situations and stay in education.
16. Children who go missing are routinely offered return home interviews. These explore reasons for absence and associated risks. Episodes of going missing are escalated when needed, and weekly multi-agency meetings monitor patterns closely, although minutes are not always recorded on children's files. This approach helps workers to gain an understanding of the reasons for absence and supports activities to reduce episodes of going missing and associated risks.
17. Strong partnership working between teams supports an effective response to electively home educated children and children missing education. Leaders maintain strong relationships with schools to ensure that vulnerable pupils with poor attendance are supported and challenged.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

18. Since the last inspection, Haringey has fully addressed all the identified areas for improvement and practice for children in care has been strengthened significantly. Decision-making is clearer, management oversight more consistent and outcomes for children have improved. A sharp focus on children's lived experiences underpins sustained improvements in care planning and permanence.
19. Children enter care at the right time and benefit from child-centred, trauma-informed practice. Social workers know children well, carry out skilled direct work with them and advocate effectively for their views to influence decisions. Case recording is clear and current, consistently reflecting children's voices, including those who have additional needs.
20. Children's care and permanence planning are strong and purposeful. Managers and practitioners are tenacious in securing culturally appropriate, well-matched

placements, with many children living in stable, long-term foster homes or their own family network when safe and appropriate. When children are living in residential settings, these are mostly meeting their needs, and no children were living in unregistered settings. Life-story work begins early and is creative and meaningful, supporting children to understand their identity, history and care journey.

21. Placement stability is a strength, with most children settled in nurturing, stable homes where they feel a strong sense of belonging. Foster and kinship carers provide sensitive care, including for children with complex needs, and many offer long-term commitment into adulthood through 'staying put' arrangements or through child arrangement orders or special guardianship orders.
22. Management oversight is regular and reflective, maintaining a clear focus on outcomes. Statutory visits and reviews are timely and purposeful, and independent reviewing officers add value by supporting children's participation and ensuring that plans remain child centred.
23. Children who go missing or who are at risk of exploitation receive a well-coordinated, multi-agency response, with effective return home interviews and strong oversight through regular monitoring and partnership forums.
24. Children's health and emotional wellbeing are supported very well. Assessments are timely, children can promptly access specialist mental health services, and carers ensure that children attend routine appointments. High-quality direct work and the nurturing, predictable care provided by foster and kinship carers help strengthen children's emotional security, identity and resilience.
25. Children's education is prioritised, with strong personal education plans (PEPs), high-quality, targeted support and effective use of pupil premium funding. Leaders of the virtual school have had an important role in strengthening support for children in care since the last inspection, particularly in relation to PEPs. The same central ethos of corporate parenting translates to children in care placed outside the borough, and the headteacher of the virtual school successfully maintains strong, positive relationships with key links for special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) and admissions as well as schools in other boroughs.
26. Fostering services are well led, with effective recruitment, assessment and support for carers and children. Carers and adopters report positive experiences, valuing the training, communication and stability-focused support they receive. Supervising social workers know families well, relationships are positive, and initiatives such as the foster home hub promote stability for children. Carers value regular communication from managers, which helps them feel informed and supported.
27. Relationships with the regional adoption agency (Adopt London North) are strong, ensuring a clear understanding of children's needs and informing targeted

recruitment and thoughtful matching, including for early permanence. Training in child permanence reports has improved report quality. Leaders understand national sufficiency challenges and are working proactively to mitigate them. Recruitment is wide-ranging and research-informed, including work to address barriers for Black and Global Majority families.

28. Adopters report very positive experiences, feeling heard, supported and treated sensitively. They value the breadth of training and research-informed learning, especially the preparation for early permanence and opportunities to hear directly from adopters and adopted adults.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

29. Care leavers in Haringey receive an exceptional service from highly skilled, experienced and committed practitioners. All staff develop strong, trusted and sustained relationships with young people, and they demonstrate a deep understanding of their needs, interests and aspirations. They are clear about what meaningful progress looks like and how it can be achieved. Practitioners are consistently ambitious for young people and go the extra mile, acting with determination and persistence to help them succeed.
30. Transition arrangements for young people aged 16 and above are applied flexibly. Although the formal transition point to care-leaving social workers is 16, transfers take place at a time that best suits the young person. This flexible, needs-led approach is also evident at age 18, with progression from social workers to personal advisers (PAs) support occurring within a considered time frame that reflects individual circumstances.
31. When young people have additional needs, all practitioners look beyond medical diagnoses, actively challenge stigma, and focus on each young person's strengths and potential, supporting young people's confidence and self-esteem.
32. Workers speak about young people with pride and genuine admiration, using terms of endearment that reflect the nurturing relationships they have built with them. A consistently embedded culture across the service ensures that young people are approached with sensitivity, kindness and respect.
33. Young people are really well supported to settle and integrate into communities that are familiar to them and where they feel comfortable. They are supported to develop highly positive, long-term relationships. They speak overwhelmingly positively about the range of social, recreational and enrichment opportunities available in Haringey.
34. Workers routinely seek young people's views, act on their feedback and encourage them to actively shape service improvement. Some young people talked to inspectors about being involved in updating the local offer, describing meaningful and effective participation. Young people are well informed about how

to access support and their entitlements, including free prescriptions and discounted travel and are aware of how to access these

35. PAs are alert to changes in young people's emotional wellbeing and demonstrate curiosity and responsiveness when a young person does not present as their 'usual self'. PAs are effective at identifying emerging vulnerabilities and they intervene before issues become more serious or acute. This level of understanding and intuition ensures that young people are supported well through difficulties, and, if risks escalate, workers complete detailed and thoughtful risk assessments that promote ongoing vigilance, curiosity and responsive care planning.
36. When young people present with a wide range of complex needs, workers have shown tenacity and emotional intelligence, maintaining regular contact, accompanying young people to appointments, and working closely with adult mental health teams, care coordinators and community networks. This has helped reduce isolation, promote safety and build confidence, even where progress is fragile or non-linear. Young people's emotional and physical health needs are prioritised and reviewed regularly, with mental health support that is extensive, timely and readily accessible. Practitioners' work is central to maintaining stability, mitigating risk and supporting progress at a pace that each young person can manage. This includes mental health workers being available at the care leavers hub 2 days a week to offer direct support to young people.
37. Where siblings are open to the service, they are supported by the same PA. This thoughtful and deliberate approach promotes young people's identity needs and ensures that workers become trusted members of their personal networks.
38. PAs demonstrate consistently strong reflective practice and self-awareness, recognising their own biases and limitations. Where gaps in skills or knowledge are identified, they proactively draw on the strengths of colleagues who hold an equally valuable but different skillset.
39. PAs visit young people regularly, in a range of settings, and at a frequency that reflects their individual needs and preferences. Visit records are detailed, cover key issues, and consistently reflect the voice and contribution of young people.
40. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children who are care leavers receive comprehensive, well-coordinated support from specialist workers. This includes assistance with leave to remain applications, attendance at Home Office interviews and timely enrolment on English for speakers of other languages (ESOL) courses. Interpreters are used appropriately and consistently as language skills develop.
41. Care leavers in custody receive prompt visits, and PAs work proactively to ensure that needs are met both during custody and on release. Support for care leavers who are parents is similarly extensive, with regular multi-agency visits before and after birth. Support plans remain in place for as long as young people need them

and include a clear focus on the needs of their babies and children, enabling young people to develop confidence in their parenting role.

42. The council's participation workers are highly valued. They proactively raise young people's awareness of their rights and entitlements through the local offer and facilitate access to enriching opportunities that young people may not otherwise experience, such as attending West End theatre productions.
43. Plentiful and well-tailored support services help young people achieve their aspirations in education, employment and training. Young people have good access to services that promote independence, social engagement and participation in community activities. This ensures they receive consistent guidance across all aspects of their lives, building confidence and progressing towards long-term goals. Young people told us how they appreciated the employment advisers and support workers offered through a commissioned service that helps them find work experience and placements.
44. PAs work proactively with care leavers to build their independent living skills, including practical tasks such as cooking, securing identification documents and attending appointments. PAs are patient and flexible, working at the young person's pace. Accommodation is consistently suitable, with choices that reflect familiarity and comfort within young people's communities. Young people described being 'pushed to do better' and said they felt seen, understood and cared for.
45. Pathway plans are comprehensive, with most completed collaboratively with young people. Actions are clear, measurable and achievable, supporting timely progress. While most plans include appropriate contingencies, this is not yet consistent across all plans. Young people's views are central throughout the planning process. Where a young person chooses not to engage, PAs continue to develop plans based on what they believe the young person's needs are, maintaining a strong focus on their wellbeing.
46. When children or young people transition from one worker to another, these changes are managed sensitively and in line with their wishes, with moves taking place at a pace that feels right for them. Young people reported positively on continued support from their social worker beyond the age of 18, which they valued highly. All young people spoke positively about their accommodation and the practical support they received in preparing for independent living.
47. When care leavers reach 21 years, they can continue to receive a service until they are 25 years old if they need this. Where there is increased vulnerability, their PAs suggest this support even when care leavers do not see a need themselves. Ongoing arrangements for care leavers to keep in touch are clearly stated and managed through a returning care leaver service for advice and support.

48. Staff benefit from continuous professional development, contributing to highly skilled, stable teams operating within a cohesive and supportive 'family pod' model. Teams describe a collaborative, family-like culture, with strengths shared to enhance learning. Managers are accessible, provide day-to-day guidance and deliver regular, high-quality supervision.
49. Tracking systems are effective, and the returning care leaver panel flexibly prioritises support for care leavers aged 21 to 25. Caseloads are manageable, enabling the development of high-quality, trusting relationships. The workforce is diverse and reflective of the communities it serves, fostering a culture which is inclusive and welcoming.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

50. Senior leaders actively recognise and prioritise the needs of children and young people. They know children individually, have relationships with them and view them as 'our children'. Political and corporate leaders have a clear understanding and grip of the main challenges faced across the borough in improving the lives of their most vulnerable children. Political leaders are highly supportive and have prioritised children's social care despite significant financial pressures. There is ongoing investment in strengthening and developing services, with a continuing commitment, clear vision and strategy ensuring that children and young people are at the heart of Haringey's future plans.
51. Leaders know their services very well. The self-evaluation is an accurate reflection of what inspectors have found. Leaders are ambitious to build on existing strengths and practice developments. They have continuously reviewed and realigned practice, embracing the direction of change through the social care reforms.
52. The director of children's services has developed and retained a strong and stable senior leadership team, and been a steady, reasoned and stable influence across the council and the wider partnership. Changes to the senior leadership team since the last inspection in 2023 have brought continued rigour and pace to improving practice for children and families, in partnership working with key strategic allies.
53. This is particularly evident in the reduced number of children entering care, achieved through a focus on early intervention, prevention and strong social work practice. Leaders are actively responding to financial constraints in the sector by maximising opportunities within the social care reforms, strengthening partnership working, promoting family-led planning and streamlining the multi-agency offer.
54. This strategic focus has brought about other achievements since the last inspection. Examples include work on stop and search in conjunction with the Metropolitan Police, the development of family and youth hubs and the

assessment hub, the innovative use of music as a medium to engage children across the borough, and the work of the Haringey learning partnership. This has created appropriate pathways and opportunities for young people and helped to reduce exclusions, particularly for young Black boys.

55. Leaders have made significant progress since the last inspection and a subsequent focused visit in those areas identified as needing improvement. Throughout this inspection, inspectors saw that all the areas for improvement have been addressed and practice has improved significantly.
56. Leaders' commitment to corporate parenting is strong and well established. The council's strategic plan for children in care sets out a clear vision grounded in permanence, stability and improved life chances. It articulates priorities that reflect a very good understanding of local need, including placement sufficiency and children's emotional wellbeing and educational progress. Effective oversight by a corporate parenting advisory committee (CPAC) chaired by the lead member has helped to ensure that strategic ambition translates well to effective operational delivery of timely, child-centred planning.
57. The voice and influence of children and young people are well developed. They are actively encouraged to engage in the work of the CPAC and in wider strategic developments through the 'Aspire' participation group, 'Take Over' days and the newly elected youth council. This approach is grounded in what leaders call the 'Haringey Way', embedding relationship-based, strengths-focused, systemic and trauma-informed practice. These principles create a consistent professional approach that prioritises children's lived experience, builds resilience and recognises the wider inequalities shaping family life. Equally, families' voices have been heard through the SEND 'Power' parent and carer forum and through feedback to inform the early help strategy. The emphasis on hearing children's and family's voices and using evidence-based practice strengthens the quality and consistency of decision-making.
58. Haringey's sufficiency strategy is firmly aligned with the 'Borough Plan' ambitions for a strong start in life, safe and happy childhoods, and clear pathways to success. The strategy reflects a whole-system approach to sustained improvement. The development of foster home hubs and the commissioning of additional emotional wellbeing and therapeutic support services for children, young people, schools and foster carers have helped strengthen short- and long-term placement stability for children.
59. Leaders have developed a strong, evidence-informed learning culture, and the preferred practice model is well embedded. Better support for children and young people's emotional wellbeing across schools and children's social care is helping children to stay in school and reduce exclusions. The Children's Academy provides a coherent, partnership-led model for workforce development. The academy supports career progression and promotes workforce sustainability through a 'grow your own' approach, including step-up routes, apprenticeships, international recruitment, and assisted and assessed and supported year in

employment progression. Strengthening and stabilising the workforce has been a priority for leaders, with increasing numbers of permanent staff and fewer agency workers. This means that most children are benefiting from stable relationships with well-trained, experienced and highly motivated workers.

60. Practice improvement is shaped by effective use of performance data, quality assurance activity and audit, and supported by regular management oversight. Multi-agency practice weeks and thematic audits strengthen learning across the partnership, with recent work highlighting the importance of early, coordinated and culturally responsive intervention. Recording practice is consistently strong in Haringey, with records written in age-appropriate language that helps children understand their histories and experiences.
61. A detailed and well-embedded performance framework provides leaders with a regular and detailed analysis and commentary of a wide range of measures, helping them to identify emerging issues and take actions to mitigate them. Overall, the audit programme has created a robust learning loop in which practice issues are identified, addressed through targeted development activity, and revisited through repeat audits and moderation. This has strengthened the quality of practice and supervision, enhanced professional confidence and embedded a culture of continuous improvement.
62. Practice Week activities across Haringey's safeguarding partnership have helped to drive collaborative learning and accountability, shape culture and sustain improvement across safeguarding.
63. Social workers and other practitioners are overwhelmingly positive about working for Haringey. Senior leaders have established a supportive and caring organisational culture. It is evident across the workforce that staff feel respected and valued by leaders, who listen to them and act on their feedback. Management oversight and supervision are routinely happening, supporting practice improvement and helping to ensure that plans for children are progressed effectively. The diverse workforce across all teams at all levels is a real strength in Haringey, reflecting the community the council serves.
64. Practitioners across the service feel well supported and valued by their managers and senior leaders. This helps them form a strong attachment to Haringey and deliver high-quality support to the borough's children and families.

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